Productive Families Program in Sharjah: Challenges and Prospects

By Alina Turekova

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

TABLE OF CONTENTS 1
LIST OF FIGURES 2
LIST OF TABLES 3
ABSTRACT 4
CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION 5
1.1 Background of the Study 5
1.1.1 History and Development of the Productive Families Program in Sharjah 5
1.1.2 Objectives of the Productive Families Program in Sharjah 7
1.1.3 Ecosystem Supporting the Productive Families Program in Sharjah 8
1.2 Issues and Statement of the Problem 11
1.3 Research Questions 12
CHAPTER 2: LITERATURE REVIEW 13
CHAPTER 3: METHODOLOGY 16
3.1 Introduction 16
3..2 Population, Sampling Techniques and Sample Size 16
3.3 Research Instrument 16
3.4 Data Collection Procedure 17
3.5 Data Analysis 17
CHAPTER 4: ANALYSIS AND RESULTS 18
4.1 Introduction 18
4.2 Profiles of the Participants 18
4.3 Data Analysis 18
4.3.1 Theme 1: Business Structure & Program Characteristics 19
4.3.2 Theme 2: Business Lifecycle Challenges 20
4.3.3 Theme 3: Technology Adoption 22
4.3.4 Theme 4: Skills and Competencies 24
4.3.5 Theme 5: Marketing Mix Challenges 26

CHAPTER 5: CONCLUSION 29
5.1 Introduction 29
5.2 Limitations 29
5.5 Suggestions 29
5.4 Conclusion and implications 30
REFERENCES 31
APPENDIX 35
Appendix A – Interview Questions for PFP Participants 35
Appendix B – Interview Questions for Non PFP Participants 36
Appendix C – Theme Coding Tables 37

LIST OF FIGURES

Figure 1. Sharjah Support Ecosystem for Productive Families 11
Figure 2 Annual number of productive families by age in the UAE 12
Figure 3 Annual number of productive families by type of activity, 2024 12
Figure 4 Level of Support Received by Participants 23
Figure 5 Type of Business Structure 23
Figure 6 Most Challenging Stage of Business Lifecycle 25
Figure 7 Start-up Challenges Faced by Participants 26
Figure 8 Digital Platform Usage among Participants 28
Figure 9 Contribution of Online Platforms to Sales 28
Figure 10 Digital Literacy Among Participants 30
Figure 11 Key Skill Gaps Identified 30

Figure 12 Pricing Strategies Used by Businesses ……....……..……. 32

Figure 13 Promotion Methods Used by Participants ……...32

LIST OF TABLES

Table 1 Organizations Providing Support Programs for Productive Families ……. 14

Table 2 Profile of the Participants ……... 21

Table 3 Relationships between Interview Questions, Codes, and Themes …….. 24

Table 4 Relationships between Interview Questions, Codes, and Themes …….. 26

Table 5 Relationships between Interview Questions, Codes, and Themes……... 28

Table 6 Relationships between Interview Questions, Codes, and Themes ……..……. 30

Table 7: Relationships between Interview Questions, Codes, and Themes …….. 32

ABSTRACT

The current study investigates the challenges and prospects of Productive Families Program (PFP) in Sharjah, U.A.E. With the UAE's diversification efforts, home-based businesses are playing a greater role in the country's agenda and their unique issues in the context of Sharjah have not received sufficient research attention. This study intent is to: (1) learn the nature and characteristics of productive family businesses; (2) determine the key issues experienced throughout the business life cycle and (3) explore how government support can help productive families. A qualitative exploratory design was used, and eleven program participants were interviewed semi-structured. Thematic analysis was used to analyze the data, and five major themes were derived: Business Structure and Program Characteristics, Business Lifecycle Challenges, Technology Adoption, Skills and Competencies, and Marketing Mix Challenges. The findings show that the program creates a low barrier, or gateway, to micro entrepreneurism, but there are inconsistencies in the distribution of support. Start-up and expansion hurdles faced by participants included a shortage of capital, lack of experience and quality control problems. There was a significant disparity in the use of technology from heavy social media user to no use. The top two skill deficits were in marketing and financial management. The findings of the study indicate that increased standardization of support, digital training and organized capacity building efforts can increase the effectiveness of the program. The results are applicable to the scarce UAE specific literature on productive family businesses and have implications for policy makers, program administrators and entrepreneurs.

CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background of the Study

Productive families are globally defined as families that do their income-generating activities at home or small-scale businesses with other social responsibilities. In general, social empowerment programs in the UAE, and productive families in particular, are essential in economic inclusion, entrepreneurship, and family well-being. Through training, financial assistance, and market access, these programs can make families gain productive skills, help families earn more, and work towards improving the socio-economic development of the UAE

In the UAE, and Sharjah in particular, productive family initiatives are aimed at assisting the local families in turning their traditional skills into home-based enterprises, with these initiatives often focusing on the involvement of the women, the development of the skills, and their introduction into the local and regional markets (Ministry of Community Empowerment, 2026). Such programs are aimed at not only raising the household income but also in the wider context of the UAE economy to diversify income sources, promote small and medium sized businesses, and encourage women and young citizens to start their own businesses (Ministry of Community Empowerment, 2026).

These programs seek to empower families with competencies in product development, marketing, financial management, and digital business platforms to be able to convert household activities into a sustainable source of income generating enterprises. These programs have led to the establishment of micro enterprises, increased domestic production, and improved overall economic involvement, which is in line with national development targets, including the UAE Vision 2021 and the Sustainable Development Goals (Federal Competitiveness and Statistics Authority, 2025).

The Productive Families Program in the UAE has expanded and contributed tremendously to the national economy in recent years. According to the UAE Voluntary National Review in 2022, 2,472 productive families were involved in the program in 2020, registering a 28% increase from 2018 (Federal Competitiveness and Statistics Authority, 2025). Furthermore, institutional support has grown significantly, with 129 training courses conducted and 192 marketing exhibitions held, representing a 24% increase in outreach activities since 2018 (Federal Competitiveness and Statistics Authority, 2025).

1.1.1 History and Development of the Productive Families Program in Sharjah

The development of productive family initiatives in Sharjah reflects a gradual yet strategic shift from social assistance to economic empowerment. This transformation was led by the Sharjah Social Department (SSSD), which early on recognized the untapped potential of home-based production as a sustainable means of supporting families. Rather than maintaining a traditional

model of financial aid, the department sought to enable families to generate their own income and achieve long-term independence.

This strategy started in 1995, when the idea of empowering families through home-based businesses first emerged as a priority. During this time, the initiative was considered pioneering, as it aimed to support traditional crafts and artisanal products while creating alternative income streams for households. This marked an important conceptual shift toward self-reliance, even though home-based work largely remained informal during its early stages (Ghobar, 2017).

In the early 2000s, momentum began to build toward formal recognition of these activities. SSSD played a central role in encouraging families to transition from dependency on aid to active participation in production. This period laid the groundwork for more structured interventions and highlighted the need for a legal and institutional framework to support such initiatives (Ghobar, 2017).

In 2007, a major milestone was reached with the launch of the Etimad license by the SSSD. This initiative represented a groundbreaking step in providing a legal entrepreneur to work from home without the burden of renting commercial space, the license significantly reduced fixed cost-one of the primary barriers to starting a business and opened the door for wider participation in economic activities (Ghobar, 2017).

The following year in 2008, SSSD marked an important institutional turning point. Under the guidance of Jawaher bint Mohammed Al Qasimi, a landmark dialogue session with women entrepreneurs was held at Expo Center Sharjah. This session brought together better understanding of the needs and challenges faced by aspiring businesswomen. The collaborative nature of this initiative helped shape more responsive policies and support systems (Ghobar, 2017).

In 2009, the Production Center by SSSD started to be established. This center focused on training and qualifying families receiving social assistance, equipping them with the skills necessary for home-based production. It also provided marketing channels and introduced a unified brand under which their products could be promoted, thereby enhancing visibility and market access (Ghobar, 2017).

The evolution continued in 2010 with the formal establishment of the Intaj Center. Serving as a business incubator, Intaj ensured that each home-based business developed a distinct market identity and adhered to quality standards. This marked a decisive move away from a charity-based approach toward a structured empowerment model. The center focused on key sectors such as perfumes, fashion, food, handicrafts, and creative arts, reflecting both cultural heritage and market demand (Ghobar, 2017).

Overall, the establishment of the Intaj Center can be seen as the cornerstone of this transformation. Supported by regulatory measures such as the Etimad license, introduced in coordination with the Sharjah Economic Development Department (SEDD), these initiatives created a comprehensive framework that enabled productive families to operate legally, participate in exhibitions, and build

consumer trust. Together, these efforts illustrate how Sharjah successfully transitioned from a welfare-oriented model to one centered on empowerment, entrepreneurship, and sustainable development (Ghobar, 2017).

1.1.2 Objectives of the Productive Families Program in Sharjah

The objectives of the Productive Families Program in Sharjah have two primary dimensions, namely social and economic. Socially, the program focuses on improving the quality of life of the owners participating in various projects in the program through:

1. Providing job opportunities for young people: Reducing dependence on government jobs and reducing unemployment
2. Empowering women in society: Providing an opportunity for Emirati women by starting their own project makes them an active role in Emirati society and enhances their social activity
3. Promoting the culture of innovation and creativity: Innovation contributes to finding new solutions to social problems and developing the quality of life in multiple fields, especially in technology and digital economy
4. Supporting community development: Encouraging entrepreneurship among young people who are at the beginning of their path to financial independence by providing new products and services that meet the needs of citizens in the emirate and improve the level and quality of their living
5. Increasing self-employment opportunities: It will reduce the overcrowding on government jobs
6. Supporting different groups in society: The existence of government initiatives and institutions that support the financing of these projects

Economically, the program aspires to achieve:

1. Diversification of sources of income: Diversification between the economy, technology, e-commerce and digital services reduces dependence on oil
2. Increasing GDP: Increasing emerging projects leads to increasing production from us that contribute to raising GDP
3. Attracting investments: The UAE is a fertile environment for investment
4. Creating job opportunities: Increasing start-ups means the need for more employees, which increases career opportunities for young people
5. Supporting innovation and technology: Using technology in our time means developing it and searching for modern technologies and digital solutions, which increases the competitiveness of the UAE economy globally.
6. Activating the small and medium-sized enterprises sector

1.1.3 Ecosystem Supporting the Productive Families Program in Sharjah

In Sharjah, there is a specialized ecosystem designed to scale these micro-businesses, with a focus on female entrepreneurship. Figure 1 below represents the measures that are intended to provide support.

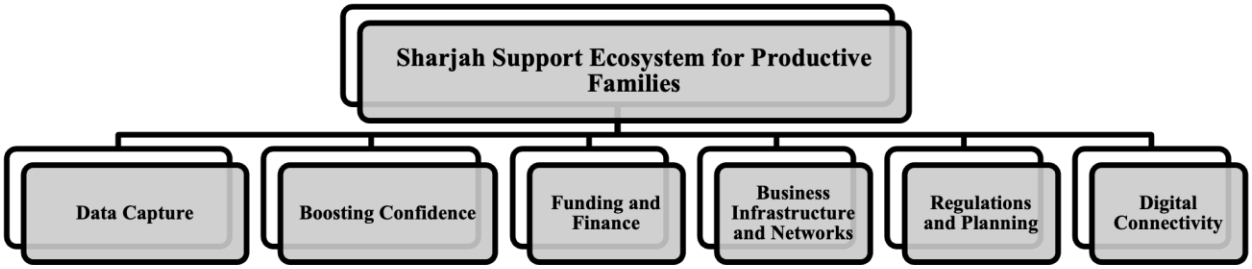


Figure 1. Sharjah Support Ecosystem for Productive Families. Sources: FCSC (2026), Ministry Community Development (2025), Ministry of Economy and Tourism (2024), (NAMA Women Advancement, 2025), Sheikh Dr. Sultan bin Muhammad Al Qasimi Portal (2024), Ookla (2026)

1) Data capture

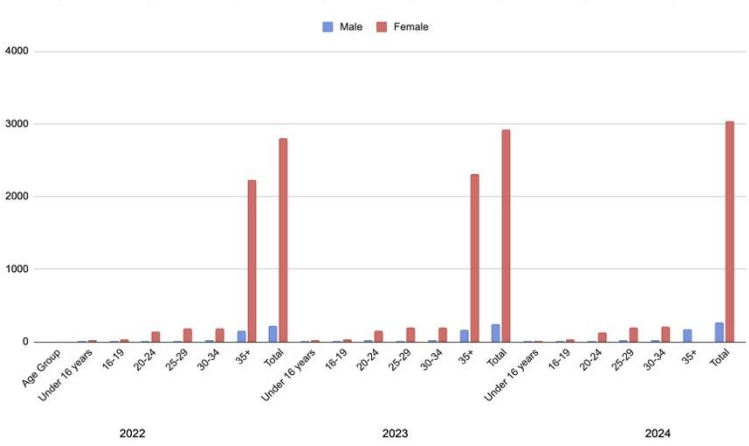


Figure 2. Annual number of productive families by age in the UAE. Source: FCSC (2026)

Data related to Productive Families Program is collected and published, which is done by the Federal Competitiveness and Statistics Centre. The data includes: the number of productive families in the country by year, emirate, gender, marital status, age and education, and by types of activity as shown in Figures 2 and 3 below.

2) Boosting Confidence

The existence of a formal program that specifically recognizes and targets productive families in a positive manner is, in and of itself, significant incentive. It signals a supportive government disposition, which is particularly evident in the case of Sharjah where several such programs have been introduced.

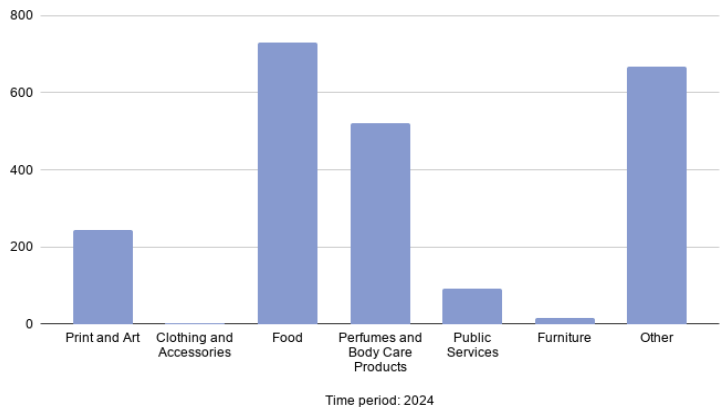


Figure 3. Annual number of productive families by type of activity, 2024. Source: FCSC (2026)

For instance, the **Matjar AlUsar AlMuntajah** initiative enables productive families across all emirates to participate in the economic sector, by providing a platform to showcase and sell their traditional products. A similar initiative is managed by the **Social Services Department (SSSD)** through the **Intaj Center (**Intaj Center, n.d.).

3) Funding and finance

The **Ruwad Program**, offered by **Sharjah Economic Development Department (SEDD) (**Ministry of Economy and Tourism, 2024)**,** is designed to provide financial and technical support within the emirate once certain requirements are met. While the program does not explicitly state that it exclusively targets productive families, it broadly covers entrepreneurs and Small and Medium Enterprises (SMEs)

4) Business Infrastructure and Networks

NAMA Women Advancement: This is one of the primary supporters of the **Sharjah Businesswomen Council (SBWC).** NAMA provides specialized training and global networking opportunities, focusing on transforming a personal "**hobby**" into a **"scalable business model" (Social Services Department, n.d.).**

The Role of Specialized Training: Organizations such as the **Sharjah Institute for Heritage** and **Reada** (under the Big Heart Foundation) provide vocational training. From an economic perspective, this represents an investment in "**Human Capital**", ensuring products meet quality standards that allow families to charge premium prices and improve profit margins. **(Ghobar, 2017; Social Services Department, n.d.).**

5) Regulation and planning

Sharjah Functional Zones: Several industrial zones in Sharjah are strategically located near main roads. This serves as a positive incentive for productive families, allowing them to boost their activity through better logistics and visibility.

Furthermore, according to **Law No. (5) of 2024 on Property Leasing in the Emirate of Sharjah,** tenants and landlords now can agree on specific land uses, which can be beneficial for the productive families. However, any violation of these terms is considered a legal ground for eviction (Sheikh Dr. Sultan bin Muhammad Al Qasimi Portal, 2024). There is also regulatory framework that is reflected through Itimad license for home-based production (SEDD, n.d.)

6) Digital connectivity

The UAE is currently ranked first in the **Speed test Global Index** published by Ookla. As of February 2026, download speeds average **681.18 Mbps**. Digital connectivity is a critical aspect of home-based businesses, as it assists families with marketing and reaching a wider audience (Ookla, 2026).

The examples of organizations providing support programs for productive families are provided in Table 1 below:

Sector	Organization\ Program\ Policy	What it Provides	Provided By	Target Beneficiaries
Social Support & Data	**Sharjah Social Services Department** (SSSD)	Identification of families, social support, program management, transaction to economic empowerment.	Government of Sharjah.	Low-income families, women, home-based entrepreneurs.
	Federal Competitiveness and Statistics Centre (FCSC)	Reporting the number of productive families by emirate, gender, etc.	UAE Government	Productive families
Regulation & Legal Framework	**Sharjah Economic Development Department** (SEDD).	Etimad License (legal permission for home businesses), regulation, market legitimacy.	Government of Sharjah.	Home-based Businesses.
Regulation & Planning	**Sharjah Municipality.**	Regulatory environment, coordination with other entities.	Government of Sharjah.	Entrepreneurs & SMEs.
Business Incubation	**Intaj Center.** (SSSD).	Training, business, Incubation, branding, product development.	SSSD.	Productive Families.
Capacity Building	**Sharjah Institute for Heritage.**	Skills development, quality improvement of traditional products.	Government\ Cultural Institution.	Artisans & Families.
Capacity Building & Empowerment	**NAMA Women Advancement.**	Entrepreneurship training, business development, global network.	Government support entity.	Women Entrepreneurs.
Business Networking	**Sharjah Businesswomen Council.** (SSWC).	Mentorship, networking, support for women-led business.	Chamber\ Government.	Women Entrepreneurs.
Business Integration	**Sharjah Heritage Days.** (UAE Festival).	Sales platform, customer exposure.	Government\ Businesses.	Home-based Businesses.
Business Integration	**Sharjah Chamber of Commerce and Industry.**	SME integration, business economic recognition.	Government\ Private Sector.	Entrepreneurs & SMEs.

(Source: Prepared by researchers (2026) using SEDD, SSSD, and NAMA data.)

Table 1. Organizations Providing Support Programs for Productive Families

1.2 Issues and Statement of the Problem

There are several issues raised by the extant literature outside the UAE and GCC about home-based businesses. The following are the five pertinent issues. Firstly, the characteristics of home-based businesses remain ambiguous in relation to cost-minimization, lack of commercial premises, and convenience-minimal travel time required *(Reuschke & Domecka, 2018).* Secondly, the issue related to the extent to which home-based businesses navigate challenges through 3 stages of their business cycles, namely seed capital stage, start up, and expansion stage *(Ali, Paguio, & Breen, 2011).* Thirdly, the literature has discussed poor management, marketing and digital skills among

home-based businesspersons *(Sukriani, 2022)*. Fourthly, there is the issue of technology adoption particularly in relation to online businesses *(Reuschke & Mason, 2022)*. Fifthly, home based businesses face issues of marketing mix (product, price, place and promotion) particularly product differentiation *(Alkaabi, 2022)*.

Most studies on home-based businesses in the GCC have been conducted in Saudi Arabia. The few works in the UAE have focused on customer perception and legal framework. There are hardly any studies that have addressed these five core issues in the context of Sharjah, UAE. Therefore, the present study fills in these research gaps. It examines the extent to which these five issues affect the Productive Families Program in Sharjah.

1.3 Research Questions

The following are the research questions for the study:

RQ1: What are the primary features and characteristics that define the Productive Families Program (PFP) in Sharjah, and how do these elements distinguish these home-based projects from traditional small business?

RQ2: To what extent do participants in the Productive Families Program face specific hurdles during different stages of the business cycle, particularly when transitioning from the initial start-up phase to expansion?

RQ3: What are the current levels of digital literacy among program participants, and in what ways do gaps in marketing and management skills influence their overall business performance?

RQ4: What specific challenges do these Productive Families face regarding "marketing mix" specifically in terms of product differentiation, cost-based pricing, and promotion?

CHAPTER 2: LITERATURE REVIEW

This chapter reviews the extant literature of issues related to Productive Families Program in Sharjah to achieve the objectives of the study: 1) to understand the nature and characteristics of productive family businesses; 2) to identify the main challenges faced by productive families; and 3) to examine the role of government support programs in assisting productive families. The researchers have reviewed 12 quality articles of which 7 were published in the period 2020 – 2026. The latest 5 years periods are chosen to ensure the articles are current and address recent developments around the study. In addition, 5 earlier foundational studies have also been considered to provide background understanding of home-based businesses and the related policies.

The researchers accessed the articles through online sources, namely Google Scholar, Research Gate, ScienceDirect, Wiley, and SSRN. The following key words were used for the search: home-based businesses, Productive Families Program, SMEs, government support programs and local entrepreneurs. The researchers then conducted bibliometric analysis on the selected articles to identify the objectives of each individual article, the country where the study was conducted, the methodology adopted, major findings, issues raised, and the gaps in literature.

Therefore, to facilitate a coherent review of the trend in the literature, the presentation has been structured according to the places where the studies were conducted and according to issues discussed in the studies. The gaps in the literature are discussed at the end of the chapter.

Most of the articles reviewed were conducted in various countries outside the UAE. The issues discussed in those articles were mixed but they can be broadly classified as follows: characteristics and performance of home-based businesses, challenges faced by entrepreneurs, government support mechanisms, and participation of home business in digital economy. For example, Reuschke and Mason (2022) conducted a study in Scotland to determine the extent to which home businesses in both rural and urban settings participate in digital economy. The findings, using Multivariate analysis, showed that home-based businesses in both settings had high proportions of online sales, although the overall impact of digital transformation was found to be limited. Similarly, Tiwasing et al. (2022) examined rural businesses in the UK and highlighted that digital technologies create growth opportunities; however, lack of infrastructure and digital skills remain major barriers, emphasizing the importance of government intervention.

In addition, Reuschke and Mason (2022) also emphasized that flexibility and lower operational expenses are the positive aspects of home-based businesses, but their involvement in the digital sphere does not always result in stable business growth, which can be considered structural constraints to the adoption of technology. Furthermore, previous research by Wang et al. (2009) confirms that home-based enterprises benefit local economies but, in most cases, they are not that available in the long run.

In terms of customer behavior and market perception, the study conducted in the UAE by Alkaabi (2022) on customer's purchasing behavior toward home-based SME products revealed that a large proportion of customers perceive such products as good quality. However, this study is limited as it focuses only on perception and uses basic methodology, making it difficult to generalize the findings overtime.

On the other hand, studies conducted in Saudi Arabia and the region have focused more on challenges and structural issues. As an example, Alhothali (2020) revealed that there were financial, social, and operational issues at various stages of business.

Similarly, Al-Masrahi and Alzamil (2024) highlighted the role of such programs in increasing household income and reducing poverty but also emphasized weak regulatory frameworks and lack of coordination among authorities. These findings are supported by Hajarian et al. (2021) which identified lack of financial support, poor infrastructure, and limited market access as key barriers to home-based business success.

The previous research by Littrell et al. (1991) once again highlights the fact that successful home-based entrepreneurs are more likely to exhibit good financial management, marketing skills and product differentiation than struggling businesses. Despite being outdated and constrained in scope, it offers background information on performance differences on home-based enterprises.

Besides this, Al Shibli et al. (2022) focused on determining the factors of entrepreneurial success and highlighted the significance of environmental, technological, and social factors alongside the necessity of more effective support systems, like awareness, training and organization.

Similarly, Ali et al. (2011) identified gaps in policy design and implementation, particularly in terms of strategic support and engagement with entrepreneurs. Wang et al. (2009) further affirmed that although home-based businesses are good contributors to regional economies, they tend to be limited by limited growth prospects and lack of structured policy integration. Earlier studies such as those conducted in New Zealand (Wilson et al., 2004), Australia (Ali et al., 2011), and ANZAM (Wang et al., 2009), provide general insights into the nature, contribution, and support mechanisms of home-based businesses. The study by Wilson et al. (2004) specifically examined home-based entrepreneurs in New Zealand and identified key characteristics such as small-scale operations, lifestyle orientation, and limited growth potential, along with benefits like flexibility and low costs and challenges including isolation, limited resources, and lack of credibility. While these studies highlight important aspects such as flexibility, low cost, and economic contribution, they are outdated and do not reflect recent developments in digital transformation and modern policy frameworks. Additionally, Reuschke and Domecka (2018) highlighted challenges such as regulatory frameworks, business infrastructure, and digital connectivity, but did not evaluate the effectiveness of such policies in real-world settings.

The engagement of home-based businesses in the digital economy (Reuschke and Mason, 2022) further reinforces that the retail transformation is an important enabler but not a sufficient

condition for business success. The analysis reveals that even with increased online sales engagement, majority of the businesses still conduct their operations offline, which underscores the existence of a digital gap.

Although these studies have used the term home-based businesses, it is almost like the concept of Productive Families Program in Sharjah. However, the gaps in these studies lie in context specific. For example, the study conducted in Scotland was in an environment that is predominantly European, with large Christian population, and adopting a convention business legal framework. In contrast, the UAE is largely influence by Arab culture, the religion of Islam and a dual business regulatory framework (conventional and Islam). Hence, it will be interesting to examine issues from the UAE context.

Moreover, many studies do not distinguish between family-based enterprises and individual entrepreneurs, which is a key feature of the Productive Families Program.

In contrast, local research in Saudi Arabia, Iran and Oman offers more contextual relevance to the UAE, nevertheless, it does not offer detailed assessment of structured government initiatives like the Productive Families Program. Moreover, they fail to appropriately incorporate digital transformation, policy effectiveness, and long-term sustainability under one analytical framework.

On the other hand, two studies reviewed were conducted in Saudi Arabia and one of the studies was conducted in the UAE. Although these studies are relevant in terms of context specific, the gaps lie in the lack of comprehensive analysis of program effectiveness, absence of robust methodologies, and limited focus on digital transformation and long-term sustainability of productive family initiatives.

Overall, therefore, the gaps in the literature are lack of UAE-specific studies on Productive Families Program, limited integration of digital and traditional business models, absence of comparative analysis across countries, weak methodological approaches in existing studies, and lack of evaluation of government support programs in terms of effectiveness sustainability. The present study fills these research gaps by examining the Productive Families Program in Sharjah in a comprehensive manner, incorporating aspects of digital participation, government support, and socioeconomic impact within the UAE context.

CHAPTER 3: METHODOLOGY

3.1 Introduction

The research project has a qualitative method in the form of interview survey to achieve the primary objectives of the study, which are: examining the differences between the characteristics of Productive Families Program in Sharjah and home-based businesses in other countries; examining the challenges that Productive Families Program in Sharjah face in 3 stages of business cycles, namely seed capital stage, start up, and expansion stage; examining the extent to the Productive Families Program in Sharjah has adopted technology for online businesses; investigating the levels of management, marketing and digital skills among participants of the Productive Families Program in Sharjah. The study has employed a qualitative exploratory method for its research design. Exploratory research design was deemed necessary since the researchers had limited understanding of many issues regarding the "Productive Families Program" in Sharjah, the UAE. According to Robson (2002), exploratory studies are used to find out what is happening, particularly in little–understood situations to seek new insights, ask questions and assess phenomena in a new light to generate ideas and hypotheses for future research.

3..2 Population, Sampling Techniques and Sample Size

The targeted population for the study is largely participants of the "Productive Families Program" in Sharjah, the UAE. The population was purposeful as the targeted participants were considered good sources of information because of their knowledge, practical experience and ability to describe events or some part of the events under study (Sandelowski, 2000).

The selection of the participants was based on purposive sampling, which was deemed suitable for exploratory research, and for deliberate selection of individuals whose experiences provide in-depth insights (Neuman, 2014). This method allowed the researchers to select relevant participants based on prior knowledge of the population that met the specific objectives of the study (Sosoulski & Lawrence, 2008). The total sample size of the study was eleven participants. This sample size is assumed to be sufficient for achieving the objectives of the study. Robson (2002) argued that there is no set number of interviews needed for a flexible design study.

3.3 Research Instrument

The interview questionnaire was designed by the researchers in both English and Arabic to carter for wider audience. The questionnaire comprised mainly open-ended questions. The researchers adopted Creswell's (2007) Interview Protocol Form to design the questionnaire. The interview

questionnaire was designed into two parts. The first part covered the Interview Information, which consisted of the Interviewee Code, date, time, location, duration of the interview, and the Interviewer. The second part focused on specific issues related to the "Productive Families Program" in Sharjah, the UAE. The interview questions (see Appendix 1) were validated by course instructor. Sandelowski (2000) suggested involving outsider-experts to validate research questions.

3.4 Data Collection Procedure

The data for this study was collected through individual semi–structured interviews, which were conducted face-to-face and online via Microsoft Forms. To maintain consistency, the authors made use of interview protocol by Creswell, J. W. (2007). The format provides a general plan for the interview including the general questions, probing questions and reminders on how to begin and close the interview. Each of the selected participant was contacted via telephone and Whatsapp to arrange the time, place and mode (face-to-face and online) for the interview. A formal letter was then sent to confirm the appointment (See Appendix 2), explaining the objectives of the study, and a set of guiding questions. Each interview took on average between 10 to 15 minutes. All data collected were coded by participant's code rather than their names to maintain confidentiality. Face-to-face interviews were recorded using phone recorder.

3.5 Data Analysis

A thematic analysis was used in the study after coding the common themes that represented the views of the interviewees. The study used the following six-step thematic content analysis method suggested by Braun and Clarke (2006):

1. The interview data from the recordings were immediately transcribed verbatim and coded for the authors to be familiarized with the data. Then the full transcripts were reviewed highlighting key words and phrases.
2. Initial codes were selected to represent any interesting features that occurred throughout the entire data set.
3. The codes were collated into five themes.
4. The themes were reviewed to ensure they aligned with their coded extracts and with the entire data set.
5. After analyzing the specifics, each theme was defined and named.
6. In the final step, the description and purpose of each theme were clearly written.

CHAPTER 4: ANALYSIS AND RESULTS

4.1 Introduction

This chapter of the study presents and analyses the findings from the qualitative interview data collected from the eleven participants interviewed on issues related to the "Productive Families Program" in Sharjah, the UAE. The chapter is further divided into two sections, namely the profiles of the eleven participants interviewed, and the interview data analysis.

4.2 Profiles of the Participants

Table 1 below presents the profiles of the eleven participants interviewed by gender, occupation and institution in the UAE. The participants have been coded with 'P' for participants followed by a number. Thus, participants 1 is coded P1; participant 2 is coded P2 and so on until participant 11.

Table 2: Profile of the Participants

No.	Gender	Age	Employment status	No. Of sources of income
1	Female	29	*Unemployed*	3
2	Male	35	Self Employed	3
3	Male	34	Employed	2
4	Male	29	Employed	4
5	Male	31	Employed	2
6	Male	28	Employed	4
7	Female	27	Unemployed	1
8	Female	30	Employed	3
9	Female	22	Self employed	2
10	Male	30	Employed	2
11	Male	23	Unemployed	1

(Source: Field Interview Data, 2026)

4.3 Data Analysis

This section presents and analyses the results of the interviews obtained from the eleven participants who were asked 22 questions each. As stated in the methodology section above, the responses were coded into the following five themes (a) Business Structure & Program Characteristics, (b) Business Lifecycle Challenges, (c) Technology Adoption, (d) Skills and Competencies, and (e) Marketing Mix Challenges. Only selected questions were converted into graphical representations. This selection was based on the ability to categorize responses into measurable groups and their relevance to the key objectives of each theme. Open-ended questions

with highly diverse responses were analyzed descriptively the time graphically to ensure clarity and avoid oversimplification of qualified data.

4.3.1 Theme 1: Business Structure & Program Characteristics

The following four questions were asked to the eleven participants to solicit their opinions on the business structure and characteristics of the "Productive Families Program" in Sharjah, the UAE:

Q1: Can you describe how the Productive Families Program in Sharjah operate?

Q2: What types of support (financial, training, regulatory) do they receive from the program?

Q3: How is their business registered, licensed, or regulated?

Q4: In your opinion, what makes the Productive Families Program different from other small or home-based businesses you are aware of (locally or internationally)?

The findings for theme 1 reveal that there are varying levels of awareness and engagement with the productive family program among the participants. A significant number of participants showed limited understanding of the program's operations, suggesting a need for improved communication or outreach strategies. On the other hand, some participants viewed the program as a formal government program aimed at supporting small-scale, home-based businesses, emphasizing its contribution to economic empowerment and income generation.

In terms of business structure, most participants described their businesses as home based, low cost, family-based businesses. These businesses are generally based on basic resources and are often started as small-scale activities that evolve into income generating businesses. This reveals that the program effectively helps in reducing barriers to entry and attracting participants with limited capital.

In terms of program support, there were varying responses. Some participants indicated they received no support, while others noted financial support, training opportunities, reduced licensing fees, and exhibition opportunities. This suggests that support may be dependent on eligibility, awareness or participation in the program.

Regarding licensing and regulation, most participants indicated that the registration process is computerized and easy, usually via websites or service centers. But some participants reported challenges or used intermediaries, suggesting that although systems are available, there is limited practical understanding of procedures.

Finally, the program was considered unique for a number of reasons, including government support, low entry costs, progressive investment opportunities and empowerment of local families. In conclusion, the results indicate that the PFP offers a supportive environment for micro enterprises but there are inconsistencies in awareness and access to support.

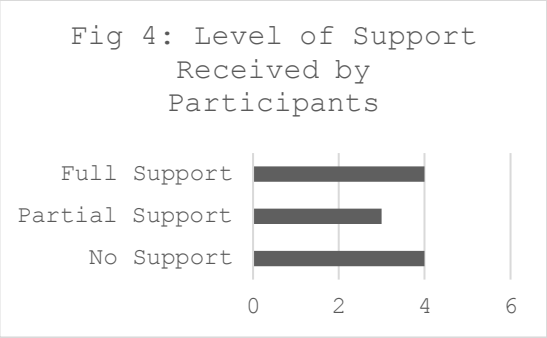


Figure 4 shows the level of support received by participants. The results reveal that the sample is almost equally split between those who received no support and those who received full support with a smaller proportion receiving partial support. This suggests that there is variability in the availability of support.

Figure 5 indicates that most businesses are home-based, with a smaller number classified as mixed/unclear. This confirms that the program supports small-scale, home-based enterprises with low entry barriers.

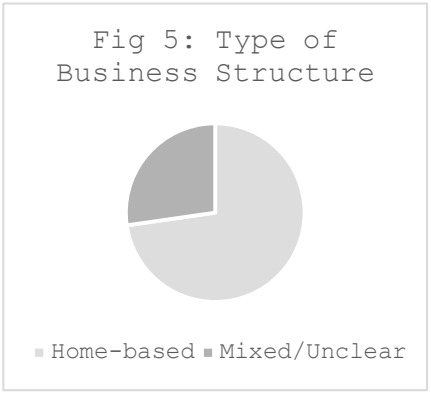


Table 3 below shows the relationship between the interview questions, codes, and the first theme developed.

Table 3: Relationships between Interview Questions, Codes, and Themes

No	Question	Codes	Theme
1	Can you describe how the Productive Families Program in Sharjah operate?	Business operation model	Business Structure & Program Characteristics
2	What types of support (financial, training, regulatory) do they receive from the program?	Program support	
3	How is their business registered, licensed, or regulated?	Licensing and registration	
4	In your opinion, what makes the Productive Families Program different from other small or home-based businesses you are aware of (locally or internationally)?	Program uniqueness	

4.3.2 Theme 2: Business Lifecycle Challenges

The following five questions were asked to the eleven participants to solicit their opinions on the business lifecycle challenges of the "Productive Families Program" in Sharjah, the UAE:

Q5: Can you describe their experience when starting the business (seed capital stage)?

Q6: What challenges do they face during the start-up phase of their business?
Q7: What difficulties are they currently facing as their business grows or expands

Q8: Which stage of the business lifecycle is most challenging for them, and why

Q9: How do they overcome the challenges faced during different stages of the business lifecycle?

The results suggest that the majority of the participants started their businesses with minimal financial capital, often using personal savings, family assistance or small loans. This aligns with the productive family businesses, which are generally set up with minimal startup capital and risk.

During the startup stage, participants identified a number of challenges, including limited market knowledge, fear of failure, building trust with customers and operational issues such as time management and sourcing labor. These insights suggest that startup entrepreneurs may experience uncertainty and need technical and emotional support to enter the market.

During the expansion stage, challenges included financial constraints, increased costs, difficulty finding employees, and quality control. The expansion stage was often linked with greater pressure and responsibility and was a challenging stage for many. Specifically, balancing growth with quality control was a significant issue.

When participants were asked which stage of the business lifecycle was the most difficult, the responses were split between startup and expansion stages. The startup stage was seen as challenging because of the uncertainty and inexperience, while the expansion stage was viewed as challenging because of resource allocation and scalability. This suggests that the challenges that the business encounters are ongoing throughout their life cycle.

To overcome these challenges, participants primarily most informal mechanisms including seeking advice from experienced people, learning from experience, planning and collective decision making. The limited reference of institutional support indicates that entrepreneurs rely on their social networks and learning processes.

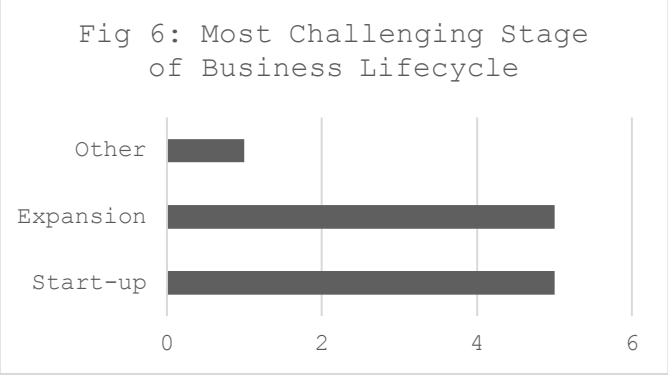


Figure 6 shows that the participants are equally split between the startup and growth stages as the most difficult periods. This implies that firms encounter problems both at the startup stage (due to uncertainty and inexperience) and at the expansion stage (due to financial and operational constraints).

Figure 7 shows the key challenges faced during the startup stage, such as inexperience, psychological factors (such as fear of failure), operational problems and trust issues with customers. This highlights the difficulties of entering business despite low financial barriers.

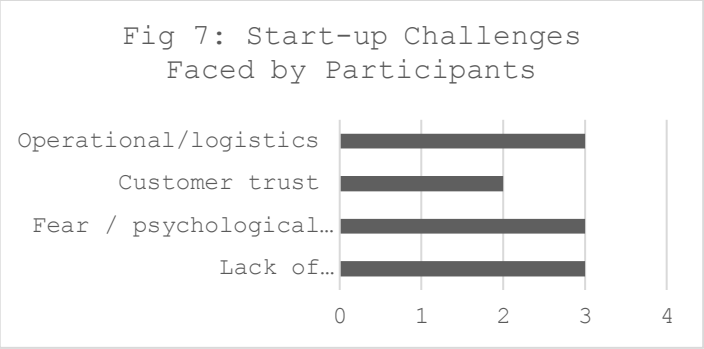


Table 4 below shows the relationship between the interview questions, codes, and the second theme developed.

Table 4: Relationships between Interview Questions, Codes, and Themes

No	Question	Codes	Theme
5	Can you describe their experience when starting the business (seed capital stage)?	Seed capital challenges	Business Lifecycle Challenges
6	What challenges do they face during the start-up phase of their business?	Start-up barriers	
7	What difficulties are they currently facing as their business grows or expands?	Expansion constraints	
8	Which stage of the business lifecycle is most challenging for them, and why?	Operational challenges	
9	How do they overcome the challenges faced during different stages of the business lifecycle?		

4.3.3 Theme 3: Technology Adoption

The following five questions were asked to the eleven participants to solicit their opinions on the technology adoption of the "Productive Families Program" in Sharjah, the UAE:

Q10: Do they use digital platforms or online tools for their business? If yes, which ones?

Q11: How do they use technology in their daily business operations (e.g., sales, marketing, communication)?

Q12: To what extent do they rely on online platforms for generating sales?

Q13: Have they received any training related to digital tools or e-commerce?

Q14: What improvements would they like to see in terms of technological support?

The results reveal a diverse level of technology use among the participants, from none to extensive use of digital platforms. Some participants indicated no usage of digital tools or platforms, while others showed a high level of reliance on social media, artificial intelligence (AI) and online communication platforms for their business.

When it comes to digital platform usage, many participants use social media platforms as their main digital tool, while others either use simple tools like WhatsApp and Excel or do not use digital platforms at all. This variation reflects the disparity in digitalization among businesses.

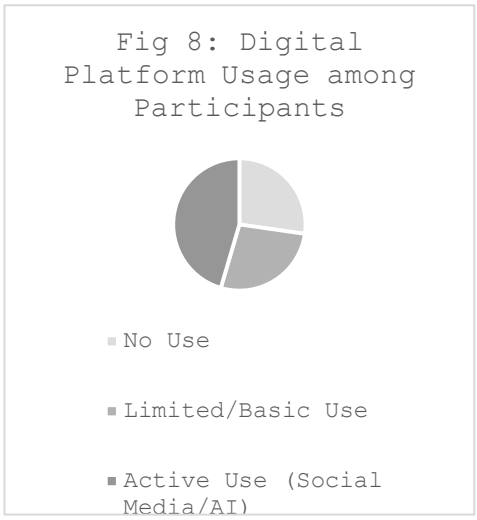
In terms of business operations, digital platforms are primarily used for marketing, communication and generating ideas, especially social media and AI platforms. However, it is used in an informal way and for basic purposes, rather than advanced e-commerce platforms.

Contribution of online platforms to sales varies significantly. While some participants reported that a significant part of their revenue is generated online, suggesting high digital dependency, others reported that they do not rely on online platforms at all.

Regarding digital training, most participants indicated they did not receive training, instead they relied on self-learning or hiring experts. Only a few participants reported training, primarily on updates in technology.

Finally, participants reported a need for improvements in technological support, such as increased social media presence, e-commerce integration, access to AI experts and government-backed digital infrastructure. These findings highlight the importance of enhancing digital capabilities to improve business performance and competitiveness.

Figure 8 demonstrates that while some participants are actively engaged with digital platforms (such as social media and AI tools), others are only using basic tools or not using digital platforms at all. This shows unequal technology use among participants.



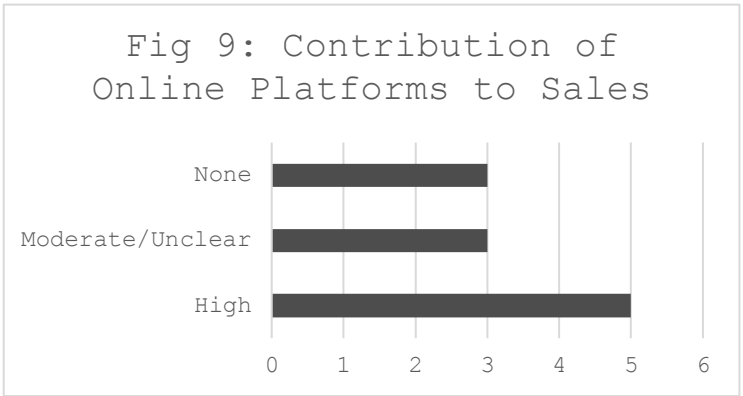


Figure 9 shows that while many participants make a high percentage of their sales through online platforms, others do not use them at all. This suggests a digital divide in the degree to which businesses benefit from online platforms.

Table 5 below shows the relationship between the interview questions, codes, and the third theme developed.

Table 5: Relationships between Interview Questions, Codes, and Themes

No	Question	Codes	Theme
10	Do they use digital platforms or online tools for their business? If yes, which ones?	Digital platform usage	Technology Adoption
11	How do they use technology in their daily business operations (e.g., sales, marketing, communication)?	E-commerce adoption	
12	To what extent do they rely on online platforms for generating sales?	Online sales contribution	
13	Have they received any training related to digital tools or e-commerce?	Digital training	
14	What improvements would they like to see in terms of technological support?	Technological improvements	

4.3.4 Theme 4: Skills and Competencies

The following four questions were asked to the eleven participants to solicit their opinions on the skills and competencies of the "Productive Families Program" in Sharjah, the UAE:
Q15: How would you describe their ability to manage their business (e.g., planning, budgeting, decision-making)?
Q16: What marketing strategies do they use to promote their products or services?
Q17: How confident are they in using digital tools (e.g., social media, online sales platforms)?
Q18: What skills are most important for improving their business?

The results revealed that the participants have moderate to strong managerial skills, especially in planning, budgeting and decision making. However, these skills are often acquired through on-the-job experience rather than formal education, and in some instances, decisions are outsourced to experts.

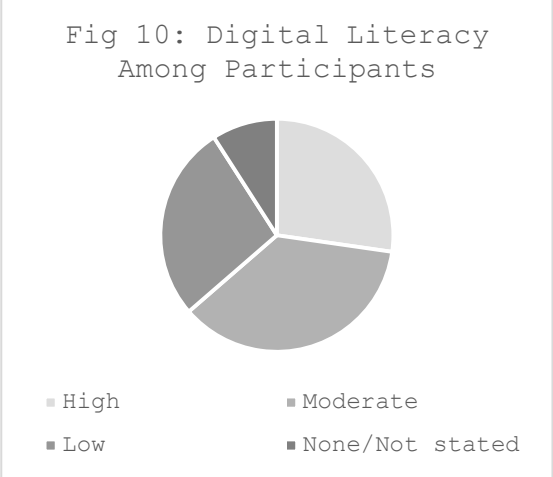
Participants' marketing strategies were generally informal and unstructured, with a strong emphasis on social media, word of mouth, discounts and customer satisfaction. Few participants

reported using formal marketing strategies, suggesting a lack of strategic planning in promoting their businesses.

There were diverse digital literacy levels across participants. Some participants were highly confident in their ability to use digital tools, while others indicated limited knowledge or that they only used basic features. This suggests digital skills gap among participants.

Participants also identified a need for improvement in marketing strategy, financial management, time management, product development and communication skills. These areas of improvement suggest the need for training programs to enhance the overall capabilities of entrepreneurs in the program.

Figure 10 shows that there is a range of digital literacy skills among participants, from high to low. Some participants are highly confident in their digital skills, while others are less skilled, suggesting a digital divide that could impact business outcomes.



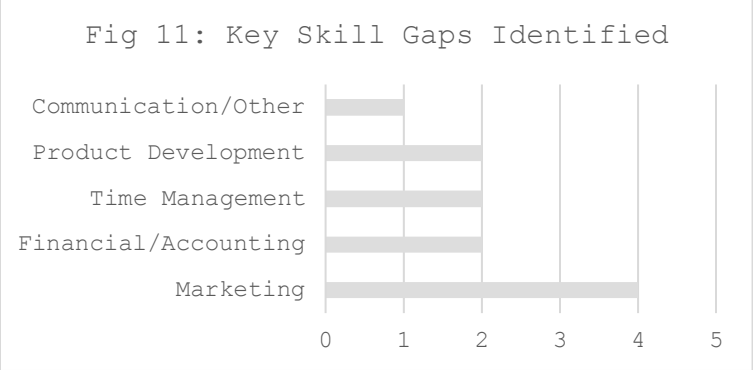


Figure 11 reveals that the most frequently mentioned skill gap is marketing, followed by financial management, time management and product development. This indicates that participants need additional training in strategic and managerial skills to enhance their business performance.

Table 6 below shows the relationship between the interview questions, codes, and the fourth theme developed.

Table 6: Relationships between Interview Questions, Codes, and Themes

No	Question	Codes	Theme
15	How would you describe their ability to manage their business (e.g., planning, budgeting, decision-making)?	Managerial skills	

16	What marketing strategies do they use to promote their products or services?	Marketing skills	Skills and Competencies
17	How confident are they in using digital tools (e.g., social media, online sales platforms)?	Digital literacy	
18	What skills are most important for improving their business?	Skill gaps	

4.3.5 Theme 5: Marketing Mix Challenges

The following four questions were asked to the eleven participants to solicit their opinions on the marketing mix challenges of the "Productive Families Program" in Sharjah, the UAE:
Q19: How do they determine the pricing of their products or services?
Q20: What methods do they use to promote their products?
Q21: How do customers respond to their pricing and product quality?
Q22: What challenges do they face in reaching their target customers?

The results revealed that the majority of the participants used cost-based pricing, sometimes complimented with price comparisons with competitors to stay competitive in the market. This suggests the use of basic and practical pricing strategies rather than advanced pricing models.

Promotional strategies mainly relied on social media and word of mouth marketing, consistent with the low-cost nature of these businesses. There were a number of participants who also used discounts, seasonal promotions, and influencer collaborations; however, these approaches were not adopted in all cases.

The feedback from customers were largely positive, with many participants reporting satisfaction with product quality and pricing. However, some participants noted a disconnect between customer expectations and price, suggesting that issues with quality and price still exist.

As for challenges, market saturation, target audience engagement, customers' trust, and limited branding skills were the major issues identified by the participants.

Figure 12 shows that the majority of participants use cost-based pricing, with fewer using competitor-based or other pricing methods. This suggests that participants favor practical pricing strategies over advanced pricing.

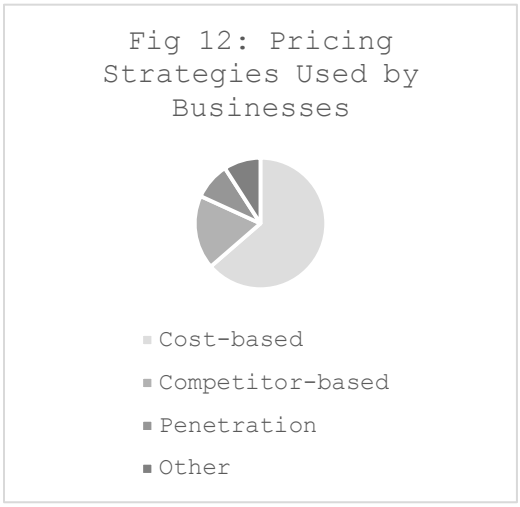


Figure 13 indicates that word-of-mouth and social media promotion are the most popular, with less use of paid advertising. This suggests the use of low cost, informal promotion methods by participants.

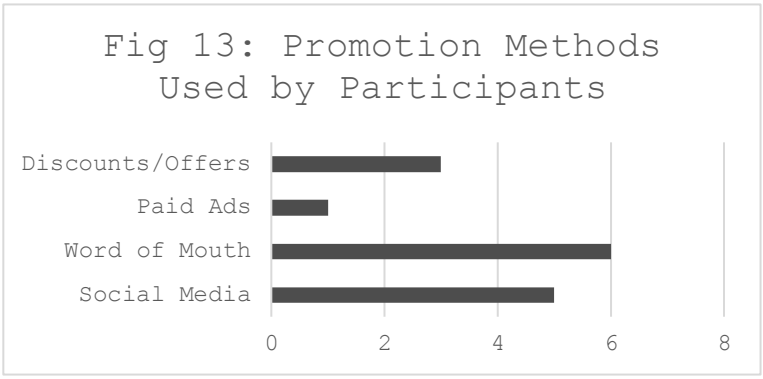


Table 7 below shows the relationship between the interview questions, codes, and the fifth theme developed.

Table 7: Relationships between Interview Questions, Codes, and Themes

No	Question	Codes	Theme
19	How do they determine the pricing of their products or services?	Pricing strategies	Marketing Mix Challenges
20	What methods do they use to promote their products?	Promotion strategies	
21	How do customers respond to their pricing and product quality?	Product differentiation	

22	What challenges do they face in reaching their target customers?	• Branding challenges • Customer perception	

Overall Summary of the Results

The key findings suggest that Productive Families businesses are driven by high levels of entrepreneurial spirit, low barriers to entry and home-based operations. But there are a number of structural and operational constraints.

A major concern is the variability in support from the program, with some participants receiving full financial and training support, while others report no support. This highlights the need for greater standardization and availability of support.

Throughout the business cycle, participants encounter challenges at both the startup and growth phases, such as inexperience, financial limitations, staffing issues and quality control. Participants often overcome these challenges through informal means, such as self-education and seeking advice from others, rather than through institutional support.

A key insight from this research is the variable use of technology. Some participants use technology platforms extensively for marketing and sales, whereas others display little or no technology use. This digital divide constrains the growth and competitiveness of some businesses and suggests a need for digital skills training and support.

Further, the participants have moderate management skills but lack formal knowledge in areas like marketing, finance and planning. Marketing is largely informal, with social media and word-of-mouth being the main forms of promotion, and cost-based pricing.

In conclusion, although the Productive Families Program offers a platform for entrepreneurship and economic empowerment, the results indicate that the program's effectiveness can be improved by raising awareness, ensuring regular support, building digital capacity and providing targeted skills training.

CHAPTER 5: CONCLUSION

5.1 Introduction

This section concludes the research, provides suggestions and limitations of the study for future research on the topic. It also touches on some implications of the study that could be beneficial for productive family businesses

5.2 Limitations

1. Demographical variations like education were not extensively measured. The differences in responses by age, gender were not analyzed. There was not a large diversity in the age of the respondents
2. Even though the research methodology applied in the research does not require a large sample, the research with larger number of respondents is expected to provide more insight
3. Most of the respondents were employed at the same entity, thus collecting responses from more diverse backgrounds could be conducted in the future research
4. The skill level was self-assessed, which might not be always credible

5.5 Suggestions

Due to the limitations mentioned, the following are recommended for future research:

1. Generalizing the sampling to ensure representativeness of different age, education groups from different workplaces.
2. Increasing the sample, utilizing other research methodologies
3. Implementing and developing scales for enhanced skill level measuring

4. Discovering reasons for the existing levels of awareness about the program

5.4 Conclusion and implications

Through this research it was possible to fill the gap regarding the productive families, since not many studies were found on this topic, specifically in Sharjah. It was found that productive families are often low-cost home-based family businesses that utilize basic resources to engage in income-generating activities. Not all of them use all the opportunities provided by government. Productive families face challenges in the seed and expansion stages, can be described with uneven levels in terms of their digital literacy, finance, accounting skills, with some other skills they are interested in improving (marketing, product development). One of their largest challenges are related to the promotion and price, strong competition and gaining customers' trust.

This study suggested several implications that could benefit productive families. These include providing better awareness and clearer licensing guidance can support business formalization, since some of the respondents showed unawereness regarding some of the program's initiatives. Providing access to expert support could improve decision-making and reduce informal reliance, which is practices amoung the participants of this study. This could help in reducing the time of arriving to a valuable advice. Formal digital training can improve technology use and efficiency. Targeted training can close specificskill gaps and improve management abilities and product quality. Better pricing and marketing knowledge can boost competitiveness. All of these could benefit the growing sector of productive families in Sharjah, contributing to the economic diversification, economic growth and social empowerment.

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APPENDIX

Appendix A – Interview Questions for PFP Participants

1. Can you describe how your business operates?
   هل يمكنك وصف كيفية عمل مشروعك؟
2. What types of support (financial, training, or regulatory) do you receive for your business?
   ما أنواع الدعم (المالي، التدريبي، أو التنظيمي) التي تتلقاها لمشروعك؟
3. How is your business registered, licensed, or regulated?
   كيف يتم تسجيل أو ترخيص أو تنظيم مشروعك؟
4. What makes your business different from other small or home-based businesses you are aware of?
   ما الذي يميز مشروعك عن غيره من المشاريع الصغيرة أو المنزلية التي تعرفها؟
5. Can you describe your experience when starting your business (seed capital stage)? **(optional)**
   هل يمكنك وصف تجربتك عند بدء المشروع (مرحلة رأس المال الأولي) ؟ (**اختياري**)
6. What challenges did you face during the start-up phase of your business?
   ما التحديات التي واجهتها خلال مرحلة بدء المشروع؟
7. What difficulties are you currently facing as your business grows or expands?
   ما الصعوبات التي تواجهها حالياً مع نمو أو توسع مشروعك؟
8. Which stage of your business lifecycle do you find most challenging, and why? **(optional)**
   أي مرحلة من دورة حياة المشروع تعتبر الأكثر صعوبة بالنسبة لك ولماذا؟ (**اختياري**)
9. How do you overcome the challenges you faced in your business lifecycle? **(optional)**
   كيف تتغلب على التحديات التي تواجهها في دورة حياة مشروعك؟ (**اختياري**)
10. Do you use digital platforms or online tools for your business? If yes, which ones? **(optional)**
    هل تستخدم المنصات الرقمية أو الأدوات الإلكترونية في مشروعك؟ إذا نعم، ما هي؟ (**اختياري**)
11. How do you use technology in your daily business operations (e.g., sales, marketing, communication)?
    كيف تستخدم التكنولوجيا في العمليات اليومية لمشروعك (مثل المبيعات، التسويق، والتواصل) ؟
12. To what extent do you rely on online platforms for generating sales? **(optional)**
    إلى أي مدى تعتمد على المنصات الإلكترونية في تحقيق المبيعات؟ (**اختياري**)

13. Have you received any training related to digital tools or e-commerce?
هل تلقيت أي تدريب متعلق بالأدوات الرقمية أو التجارة الإلكترونية؟
14. What improvements would you like to see in terms of technological support? **(optional)**
ما التحسينات التي ترغب في رؤيتها فيما يتعلق بالدعم التكنولوجي؟ (**اختياري**)
15. How would you describe your ability to manage your business (e.g., planning, budgeting, decision-making)?
كيف تصف قدرتك على إدارة مشروعك (مثل التخطيط، إعداد الميزانية، واتخاذ القرار) ؟
16. What marketing strategies do you use to promote your products or services? **(optional)**
ما استراتيجيات التسويق التي تستخدمها للترويج لمنتجاتك أو خدماتك؟ (**اختياري**)
17. How confident are you in using digital tools (e.g., social media, online sales platforms)? **(optional)**
ما مدى ثقتك في استخدام الأدوات الرقمية (مثل وسائل التواصل الاجتماعي ومنصات البيع الإلكتروني) ؟ (**اختياري**)
18. What skills do you think are most important for improving your business?
ما المهارات الأكثر أهمية لتحسين مشروعك؟
19. How do you determine the pricing of your products or services?
كيف تحدد أسعار منتجاتك أو خدماتك؟
20. What methods do you use to promote your products? **(optional)**
ما الطرق التي تستخدمها للترويج لمنتجاتك؟ (**اختياري**)
21. How do customers respond to your pricing and product quality?
كيف يتفاعل العملاء مع أسعار وجودة منتجاتك؟
22. What challenges do you face in reaching your target customers? **(optional)**
ما التحديات التي تواجهها في الوصول إلى العملاء المستهدفين؟ (**اختياري**)

Appendix B – Interview Questions for Non PFP Participants

1. Can you describe how the Productive Families Program in Sharjah operate?
هل يمكنك وصف كيفية عمل برنامج الأسر المنتجة في الشارقة؟
2. What types of support (financial, training, regulatory) do they receive from the program?
ما أنواع الدعم (المالي، التدريبي، والتنظيمي) التي يحصلون عليها من البرنامج؟
3. How is their business registered, licensed, or regulated?
كيف يتم تسجيل أو ترخيص أو تنظيم مشاريعهم؟
4. In your opinion, what makes the Productive Families Program different from other small or home-based businesses you are aware of (locally or internationally)?
في رأيك، ما الذي يميز برنامج الأسر المنتجة عن غيره من المشاريع الصغيرة أو المنزلية التي تعرفها (محلياً أو عالمياً)؟
5. Can you describe their experience when starting the business (seed capital stage)? (**optional**)
هل يمكنك وصف تجربتهم عند بدء المشروع (مرحلة رأس المال الأولي)؟ (**اختياري**)
6. What challenges do they face during the start-up phase of their business?
ما التحديات التي يواجهونها خلال مرحلة بدء المشروع؟
7. What difficulties are they currently facing as their business grows or expands?
ما الصعوبات التي يواجهونها حالياً مع نمو أو توسع مشاريعهم؟
8. Which stage of the business lifecycle is most challenging for them, and why? (**optional**)
أي مرحلة من دورة حياة المشروع تعتبر الأكثر صعوبة بالنسبة لهم ولماذا؟ (**اختياري**)
9. How do they overcome the challenges faced during different stages of the business lifecycle? (**optional**)
كيف يتغلبون على التحديات التي يواجهونها في مختلف مراحل دورة حياة المشروع؟ (**اختياري**)

10. Do they use digital platforms or online tools for their business? If yes, which ones? (**optional**)
    هل يستخدمون المنصات الرقمية أو الأدوات الإلكترونية في مشاريعهم؟ إذا نعم، ما هي؟ (**اختياري**)
11. How do they use technology in their daily business operations (e.g., sales, marketing, communication)?
    كيف يستخدمون التكنولوجيا في العمليات اليومية لمشاريعهم (مثل المبيعات، التسويق، والتواصل)؟
12. To what extent do they rely on online platforms for generating sales? (**optional**)
    إلى أي مدى يعتمدون على المنصات الإلكترونية في تحقيق المبيعات؟ (**اختياري**)
13. Have they received any training related to digital tools or e-commerce?
    هل تلقوا أي تدريب متعلق بالأدوات الرقمية أو التجارة الإلكترونية؟
14. What improvements would they like to see in terms of technological support? (**optional**)
    ما التحسينات التي يرغبون في رؤيتها فيما يتعلق بالدعم التكنولوجي؟ (**اختياري**)
15. How would you describe their ability to manage their business (e.g., planning, budgeting, decision-making)?
    كيف تصف قدرتهم على إدارة مشاريعهم (مثل التخطيط، إعداد الميزانية، واتخاذ القرار)؟
16. What marketing strategies do they use to promote their products or services? (**optional**)
    ما استراتيجيات التسويق التي يستخدمونها للترويج لمنتجاتهم أو خدماتهم؟ (**اختياري**)
17. How confident are they in using digital tools (e.g., social media, online sales platforms)? (**optional**)
    ما مدى ثقتهم في استخدام الأدوات الرقمية (مثل وسائل التواصل الاجتماعي ومنصات البيع الإلكتروني)؟ (**اختياري**)
18. What skills are most important for improving their business?
    ما المهارات الأكثر أهمية لتحسين مشاريعهم؟
19. How do they determine the pricing of their products or services?
    كيف يحددون أسعار منتجاتهم أو خدماتهم؟
20. What methods do they use to promote their products? (**optional**)
    ما الطرق التي يستخدمونها للترويج لمنتجاتهم؟ (**اختياري**)
21. How do customers respond to their pricing and product quality?
    كيف يتفاعل العملاء مع أسعار وجودة منتجاتهم؟
22. What challenges do they face in reaching their target customers? (**optional**)
    ما التحديات التي يواجهونها في الوصول إلى العملاء المستهدفين؟ (**اختياري**)

Appendix C – Theme Coding Tables

Theme 1: Business Structure & Program Characteristics

No	Question	Codes	Theme
1	Can you describe how the Productive Families Program in Sharjah operate?	Business operation model	Business Structure & Program Characteristics
2	What types of support (financial, training, regulatory) do they receive from the program?	Program support	
3	How is their business registered, licensed, or regulated?	Licensing and registration	
4	In your opinion, what makes the Productive Families Program different from other small or home-based businesses you are aware of (locally or internationally)?	Program uniqueness	

Responses for Theme 1

Participant	Questions			
	1	2	3	4
P1	No idea	Mohd Bin Rashid Corporation in Dubai provides material support in the form of long-term concessionary rents	Licensing is easy, which can be done online, through Tasheel or in person. However, there are few businesses operating without license.	This program is distinct because Emiratis are innovative and ambitious, which pave for them ways towards success
P2	No idea	Mainly through project opportunities and networking, no direct financial training, regulatory support	Registered initially in shams, later through economic department; supported with workspace and business environment	distinct due to diverse team combining experience and fresh ideas
P3	Home based family businesses using simple resources to generate income through products or services	Ruwad provides support such as interest free loans, free offices, and facilities for up to five years	Licensing differs discounts through Ruwad, different procedures via economic department without support	distinct due to starting from scratch, better market understanding, and changes in workforce strategy
P4	No idea	No support received	Licensing process unclear and time consuming; Completed through a representative at own expense	Government support makes these businesses strong competitors locally and globally
P5	Home based licensed families selling products our services	No support received	Registered through Dubai economic department via Mohammed bin	Distinct due to focus on quality, credibility, and international benchmarking

			Rashid SME fund	
P6	Using home resources to create family income	Government support mainly through free training courses	Licensing done with help of partner; Unclear personal knowledge of process	Distinct due to gluten free, healthy, natural recipes without preservatives
P7	Home based workers using simple capital and limited resources	No support received due to ineligibility	Licensing handled by partner through Tasheel	No response
P8	Home based work turning hobby into income	No support received	Registration handled through Tasheel	Distinct due to Emirati cultural and fashion knowledge
P9	Home based small business support program helping families turn skills into income	Financial support plus training	Home business licensing through official authorities	Distinct due to full startup support combining funding, training and business development from the beginning
P10	Low-cost program allowing families to test business ideas before large investments	Reduced licensing fees, fees exemptions, online workshops, and participation in fairs	Registration done through electronic services	Easy licensing and gradual investment model reducing financial risk and enabling step by step growth
P11	A govt initiative that improves household income through economic empowerment	Financial: reduced license fees and exemption from some government charges, provision of capital support Training: continuous workshops, online training, business	Registration is through electronic services or official websites	Distinct due to low-cost entry with gradual investment, strong government support system, opportunity for families to develop skills and business safety, focus on empowerment and income improvement, supports different talents and household initiatives.

		development programs Regulatory: monitoring by authorities, participation in exhibitions and markets General support: capital assistance to safely develop the project ; all types of support provided		

Theme 2: Business Lifecycle Challenges

No	Question	Codes	Theme
5	Can you describe their experience when starting the business (seed capital stage)?	Seed capital challenges	Business Lifecycle Challenges
6	What challenges do they face during the start-up phase of their business?	Start-up barriers	
7	What difficulties are they currently facing as their business grows or expands?	Expansion constraints	
8	Which stage of the business lifecycle is most challenging for them, and why?	Operational challenges	
9	How do they overcome the challenges faced during different stages of the business lifecycle?		

Responses for Theme 2

Participant	Questions				
	5	6	7	8	9
P1	She started from the kitchen of the house with limited possibilities , so she didn't need to save a large	She faced a problem in focusing on the project and giving it sufficient attention without neglecting the rest of her own	Expansion for her means greater responsibilities and more effort so she feels afraid and also has a lack of manpower and this puts her	The beginning stage was difficult for her because of the search for a working hand and preparing the place to	She didn't face any challenges

	amount as an initial capital	life and her personal obligations	greater responsibilities	produce a satisfactory product	
P2	He withdrew a loan from the bank, and this was his main source of financing	The biggest obstacle he faced was rejection from many sides because it was a new business in the market and had stronger and older competitors in the field	Its financial difficulty because expansion needs liquidity	Development in line with raising the ceiling of customer expectations, for example when organizing a specific event with a satisfactory result then the customer is waiting for a better result in the future	By consulting experienced people and specialists
P3	He collected capital from personal expenses and then withdrew a loan from the bank	The difficulty of starting from scratch without knowledge of the market especially since the business started in 2015 before social media	The cost of labor residences	Seasons, the summer period means stagnation in this field	Focuses on annual contracts to cover booking
P4	He started the business with a partner 50% - 50% and his percentage was from other sources of income	Termination of government transactions	Currently there is no focus on expansion	The beginning because the road was unknown and scary	By search for the source of the problem and solve it immediately before it worsens
P5	He has three partners each of	Search for suitable labor	Rising rent prices	Expansion phase	By meeting weekly, discussing

	whom paid 25% and he paid through saving from other sources of income		Running another branch dividing effort and time and focusing on two places		and voting if there is any problem and taking the opinion of the majority
P6	It was a small amount that she had collected from other sources of income	Difficulty in finding a suitable delivery company - a long time during the arrival of imported materials from abroad	Difficulty maintaining the same level of quality without having to raise the price	Expansion phase	Consulting experienced persons
P7	The capital was supported by his family	Difficulty gaining the customers trust	High shipping with recent conditions forces to raise the price and delay in the performance of obligations towards customers	The beginning	More education and development to find solutions to problems
P8	She started with a small capital because she put the possibility of failure and loss	Fear of failure	Lack of time especially since the expansion phase needs to be freed	The beginning because customers are afraid of the experience and stay away from the new	By putting forward possible solutions and developing a specific strategic plan
P9	it was funded by government agencies in the country	limited budget- the difficulty of building trust with customers- the difficulty of ability to organize time	receiving additional orders and maintaining the same quality at the same time	• Expansion phase	• by consulting taking a step quickly

P10	from other sources income	fear of loss, lack of prepared spaces in the home in advance	lack of domestic labor permits	The beginning	by daring to choose decisions
P11	from private savings	studying the business is a big challenge for the individual in how to start through it and think about accomplishing	difficult in how to manage money to improve the quality of business	Expansion phase	by handing over the subject to experienced people and those who have the biggest background about it

Theme 3: Technology Adoption

No	Question	Codes	Theme
10	Do they use digital platforms or online tools for their business? If yes, which ones?	Digital platform usage	Technology Adoption
11	How do they use technology in their daily business operations (e.g., sales, marketing, communication)?	E-commerce adoption	
12	To what extent do they rely on online platforms for generating sales?	Online sales contribution	
13	Have they received any training related to digital tools or e-commerce?	Digital training	
14	What improvements would they like to see in terms of technological support?	Technological improvements	

Responses for Theme 3

Participant	Questions				
	10	11	12	13	14
P1	No idea.	Depends on them very much, especially on social media.	High, since their profits are higher online than in the market and depend on the technology of lot.	No, since they learned by themself.	Wants to depend on technology more than depending only in themself.

P2	They are not using any but are planning to have one in the future.	Depends on AI a lot on data transactions or new ideas.	The devices they use aren't that much known to the public.	Everyone knows and are experts on using technology, but still sometimes to improve themself they take training to improve with new technologies.	If they add AI experts.
P3	Don't use them at all.	Depends on WhatsApp only.	Doesn't depend.	No.	No need.
P4	Use a personal digital that supports his own use.	Depends on their own sights.	Since their profits are higher online than in the market, they started depending on it more.	No since they have a specialist with them.	Need to take more videos.
P5	Use the AI to draft contracts, and so on.	Depends on ads.	Almost 70%.	No since they have a specialist with them.	To expand more and to increase their use of social media more.
P6	No.	Doesn't depend on anything.	Doesn't depend.	No.	Wants to have social media presents.
P7	Use social media.	Depends on social media for anything new.	High, since their profits are higher online than in the market.	No, since they have a background.	To follow and catch up with the new tactics.
P8	Use them a little bit for numerical transactions.	Depends only on Excel.	No.	No.	Don't have one, but maybe in future.
P9	Use social media.	Depends on social media.	No response actually, but since the last answer was	Yes, but in new updates only.	No response.

			social media, I guess they depend on it a lot.		
P10	Use social media.	Depends on calling and ads.	Depends on it a lot since it is the main use to communicate with customers.	Yes, and they give it free from their side.	If they get government support for e-commerce support with integrated payments and delivery.
P11	Use google devices to make their transactions with customers easier.	Depends on social media.	No idea.	Yes.	No response.

Theme 4: Skills and Competencies

No	Question	Codes	Theme
15	How would you describe their ability to manage their business (e.g., planning, budgeting, decision-making)?	Managerial skills	Skills and Competencies
16	What marketing strategies do they use to promote their products or services?	Marketing skills	
17	How confident are they in using digital tools (e.g., social media, online sales platforms)?	Digital literacy	
18	What skills are most important for improving their business?	Skill gaps	

Responses for Theme 4

Participant	Questions			
	1	2	3	4
P1	Management in general was the easiest part, budgeting was easy. Decision making was harder, given advice from specialists	Social media trends Customer satisfaction as a strategy to attract more clients.	Strongly	Packaging

		Discounts at certain annual occasions		
P2	Fully able	Customer satisfaction The work itself (presence at the event)	No answer	Market research and ideas/trends generation
P3	According to personal skills and knowledge	No formal strategy The work (maybe product) itself	Lower, to the point it seems harder than easier	Hiring more employees (or none)
P4	All the matters are delegated to the specialists	No formal strategy Customer satisfaction Excessive promotion is not welcomed	Only for simple tasks, not used for marketing plans or important consultations	Improving communication Distributing the focus across branches
P5	The mentioned matters are delegated to the specialists Some consultations are done by AI	Inflated pricing strategy	50% - 75%	Dedicating more time to the place Getting more informed about accounting matters
P6	Fully able	Friends and Family launch strategy	Does not see useful for themselves (healthy food – food delivery platforms)	Improving recipes, new ingredients and sources
P7	Fully able (academic background)	Discounts at certain seasonal occasions	At the beginner stage in terms of e-commerce and SM platforms	Customer attraction and pricing based on surrounding events
P8	Capable, needs improvement	offers	Not confident	Pricing, time management
P9	Planning, time management, managing ingredients and costs, daily decision-making are improving			Baking and product quality Good cost-based pricing Marketing Time management

	Long-term planning in development			
P10	Moderate	Mostly no strategy. New generation is more informed	Highly	Relationships, direct marketing, Courage
P11	From good to excellent			Project management

Theme 5: Marketing Mix Challenges

No	Question	Codes	Theme
19	How do they determine the pricing of their products or services?	Pricing strategies	Marketing Mix Challenges
20	What methods do they use to promote their products?	Promotion strategies	
21	How do customers respond to their pricing and product quality?	Product differentiation	
22	What challenges do they face in reaching their target customers?	• Branding challenges • Customer perception	

Responses for Theme 5

Participant	Questions			
	19	20	21	22
P1	I calculate the cost and compare it with competitors' prices, setting my prices on this basis without going beyond the commonly accepted price range.	As I mentioned earlier, exploiting occasions to set discounts and also social media.	My prices are affordable and well known, not different from the market, and customers always notice the quality of the ingredients used and see that the price is suitable for the quality, quantity, and the product offered.	The field is crowded and somewhat saturated, but there is no field without competition. However, the top is big enough for everyone. Also, if the customer is satisfied with the product, it means they will return again. Therefore, I see that competition is the problem, but customer

				satisfaction solves the problem.
P2	Based on the client's requests and also other circumstances such as shipping costs, I believe that organizing one high-quality event is better than organizing 70 events of lower quality. I care about quality, not quantity.	No response	The client always wants the lowest price and the highest quality, and we suffer from the mismatch between their requests and their budget. We, in turn, try to reconcile the price with the desires and the outcomes.	As I mentioned earlier, we knocked on many doors, but the customers' lack of trust in us was the obstacle. We knocked on 100 doors without results, but at the 101st door, we got a chance.
P3	In accordance with the cost and competitors' prices	Customers who are satisfied with the services provided tell their circle about me, and I also offer promotions and discounts, and I see this as the strongest marketing method.	We are completely satisfied with the quality of the service provided, and also regarding the prices, my prices are considered among the cheapest in the market, hence the acceptance from them.	Since the target group is mostly elderly, it is difficult for them to deal with technology or organize booking matters.
P4	We strive to retain a loyal customer, and we may offer them special discounts.	No response	They see it as very appropriate compared to the excellent service provided.	We did not encounter any problems in this regard
P5	We study market prices and have a certain profit margin between 35% and 40%.	I see that when the customer shares their experience with their surroundings, this is one of the strongest	They are completely satisfied with the quality, but regarding prices, sometimes they	We faced difficulty at the beginning knowing who the target audience was in the first

		forms of promotion. I also have an employee specialized in feedback to ensure the customer's satisfaction with their experience and how they heard about us. We also have our own website to improve customer experience.	feel that the prices are high, while acknowledging that the prices are reasonable both for the product and even for after-sales services.	place, and then we carried out the filtering.
P6	My prices are very affordable because my focus is on gaining the customer, not making money.	In the cafes near sports centers, these areas are where most people interested in their nutrition and health gather.	Both the quality and the prices are very satisfactory according to everyone's consensus.	Not trusting us because our name is new in the market and we are weak from a marketing perspective
P7	Based on the cost with a small profit margin, taking competitors and their prices into consideration	Paid advertisements Track trending events and seasonal occasions as mentioned	The quality is unmatched since the product is imported from the Netherlands, but sometimes people think the prices are high.	We are not facing any problems, thank God. We reach the target audience easily and smoothly.
P8	The prices were lowered initially to enter the market, and then they were gradually raised.	Customers talk about me, as well as my acquaintances, friends, and relatives.	They believe that the quality provided deserves higher prices because this is what they see with competitors.	I feel that the target group is difficult to reach, and until now I am looking for a suitable way to do that.
P9	Prices are usually set by calculating the	They promote their cakes mainly through social	Customers are usually happy with the pricing	No response

	cost of ingredients, packaging, time spent on each cake, then adding a reasonable profit.	media like Instagram and WhatsApp, sharing photos of their work, and also through word of mouth from satisfied customers and friends.	because it's reasonable for homemade cakes, and they like the taste and the quality.	
P10	Without study, in a manner similar to what is shown in the market	Social communication comes first, then marketing through product quality so that this product is recommended by other people.	Customers always make comparisons, and if the product quality is good, they buy it even if the price is higher than the others.	Lack of sufficient data due to the sensitivity of this personal information.
P11	Cost price + interest rate = product price	Sending the product to advertisers or photographers and uploading the photos on social media.	If the quality is excellent, the prices are reasonable for the product, as the customer can distinguish between good and poor quality.	No response